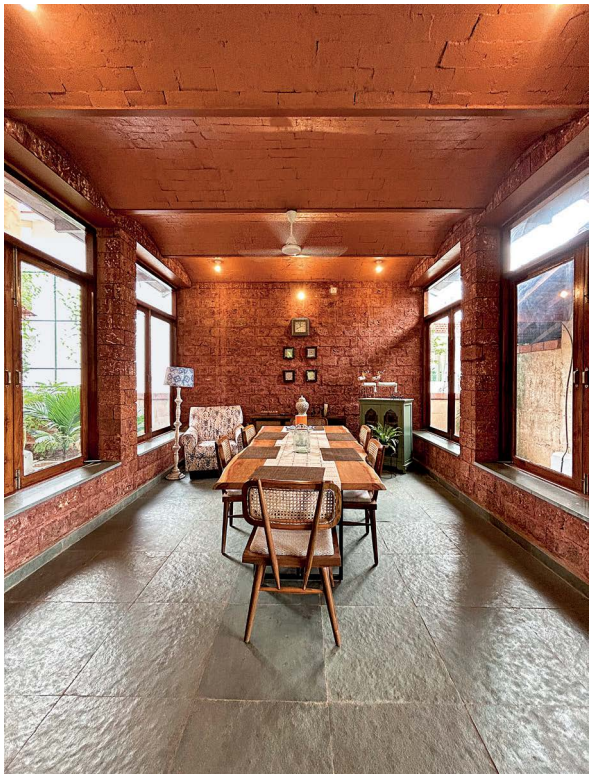


HOMES THAT BREATHE

With the mercury rising steadily, architects share projects that are cool in more ways than one

By KUSHAGRA SHARMA

The arrival of summer in India was once a time of great anticipation, but with temperatures inching higher each year and dependence on heat-emitting ACs increasing, our cities are getting trapped in a vicious cycle of the solution perpetuating the climate crime. As urban heat islands intensify, we highlight four projects that demonstrate how thermal comfort can be achieved by looking back to the future.



Photograph by SEEYA KESERKAR

Earth Advocate

In Goa, Architect Tallulah D'Silva champions a return to the soil. Moving away from energy-intensive concrete, she utilises lime-stabilised rammed earth and lateritic mud. Her project, Dhara House, uses cardinal courtyards to funnel coastal breezes, achieving a five-degree drop in indoor temperatures. "Glass and concrete are among the worst materials for the tropics. If we observe how animals build or how our ancestors lived, we can appreciate natural materials for cooling," she says. So, in this home, courtyards along each cardinal direction flank the central living area funnelling the prevailing southern breeze. Generous verandahs allow the home to breathe while greenery cocoons it. Staggered sloping roofs made of wood and clay tiles, louvered shutters and vaulted ceilings in brick all aid in ventilating and cooling the interiors. "Our mud houses reduce heat gain by 6-7 per cent... and it doesn't hurt that mud has such a positive effect on our psyche," she adds.